Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION

Is an Architecture Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The complete profile — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, the honest downsides, and what to ask before you commit.

5.0

AI EXPOSURE · LICENSED ARCHITECT / DESIGN LEAD

where 10 is most at risk

Read this one first; send the student version to them.

HIGHLIGHTING IS COLOUR-CODED

THE FINDING EXPOSURE PROTECTION METHOD & HONESTY

Before you read this — a note for parents

You're likely reading this before your child is. That's normal, and it's worth pausing on how you use it.

Don't lead with the scores. If you open with a risk number, they either get frightened and shut down, or defensive about a decision they've already made.

What this is. A facts document, not a recommendation.

A practical note: there's a separate short version written directly to them. Send them that one.

And one thing specific to architecture. The AI answer here is reasonably good. The honest problems with this career are the ones the profession has had for decades — the length of the path, and the pay relative to that length. Those deserve more of your attention than the score does, and they're the conversation most families never have properly because architecture sounds prestigious.

If your child is genuinely drawn to this, none of what follows should stop them. It should make sure they know what they're committing to, and that they've looked at two adjacent careers that reach similar money considerably faster.

The short answer

Yes at the licensed, client-facing end — but architecture is a long degree, and the value only arrives if the student completes the whole path.

Licensed architecture scores **5.0** out of 10. Production drafting scores **7.6.** Construction administration — the site-based end — scores **4.7.**

The stamp, the site and the client relationship are real protection. But the drafting years that traditionally filled the path to licensure are being automated out from under it, and the path itself is the longest of any design profession.

The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Construction administration / site	4.0	4.3	**4.7**	+0.7	Moderate
Licensed architect / design lead	4.3	4.6	**5.0**	+0.7	Moderate
Specialist (sustainability, computational)	4.8	5.2	**5.5**	+0.7	Moderate
Technical / BIM coordination	5.8	6.3	**6.7**	+0.9	Moderate–High
Production drafting	6.1	7.0	**7.6**	+1.5	High

Scores run 1–10, *where* 10 *is most at risk*. For context: *the median profession in this edition sits around* 5.5, *licensed engineering scores* 4.0, *construction management* 3.3, *and graphic design production* 8.4.

Read the table this way: the same split that runs through this whole index — the site holds, the desk drifts. Site-based construction administration is the best-protected work in the profession, and production drafting moved +1.5 in three years.

Why licensed architecture holds up — the six factors

How much of this job can AI already do?	**8.0**
How hard will it be to land that first job?	**4.5**
Does it have to be done in person, with your hands?	**5.0**
Does someone need a human they can trust and hold responsible?	**7.5**
Does the law require a licensed human?	**8.5**
How often does the job hit genuinely new, high-stakes situations?	**7.5**

EXPOSURE RAISES THE SCORE   PROTECTION LOWERS IT

Here's how licensed architecture answers them.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

A substantial and growing share of the desk work.

Drafting and documentation sets. Massing studies and floor-plan options. Rendering and visualisation. Code checking and compliance. Specification drafting. Proposals and admin.

Adoption is already substantial — a majority of architecture firms report using AI-driven software, and around 30% of design and drafting *tasks* are estimated to be automatable. Note the wording: tasks, not jobs.

The AIA's own technology survey notes that 2D CAD drafting roles are shrinking at practices that have moved to full BIM workflows — a displacement that started before generative AI and is now accelerating.

What resists: the stamp and the liability behind it, site conditions nobody drew, a client who trusts you with their money, and judgment about what is actually buildable here.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Moderate, and propped open by licensure — with a caveat covered in section 4.

The AXP requires logged experience hours under a licensed practitioner, which gives firms an institutional reason to employ and supervise candidates. That is the same mechanism protecting nursing, accounting and engineering.

And the licensure pipeline has shrunk, which has pushed licensed salaries up faster in 2024 and 2025 than in most of the previous decade. Scarcity at the licensed end is real.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

For construction administration substantially; for design work much less.

Site visits, commissioning, inspection and snagging cannot be done remotely. This is why the site-based track scores best in the profession.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

Yes — a client betting several million on a building wants a named human answerable for it, and liability follows the signature.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

Comprehensively. All fifty states require architects to be licensed, and certain drawings must be signed by one. Section 4 explains why this protection is more fragile than it looks.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

Frequently. Every site, every programme, every client is different, and the consequences of getting it wrong are physical and expensive.

The question the profession hasn't answered

This deserves its own section, because architecture is where it bites hardest of any career in this index.

The stamp is a legal monopoly, and like accounting's CPA pathway, architecture's licensure does something extra: **it mandates logged experience hours under a licensed practitioner.** Firms must employ and supervise candidates for the profession to replenish itself. That props the on-ramp open.

But what happens *inside* those hours has changed.

A candidate who spends the AXP directing generative tools and reviewing output accumulates the same hours as one who spent them drawing by hand. Are they building the same judgment?

Licensure certifies that someone has done the time. It assumes the time teaches. If the content of those years shifts from producing work to supervising work, the assumption may quietly stop holding — and the licence would continue certifying something it no longer measures.

This sorts the professions in a way worth carrying elsewhere. In nursing, medicine and the trades, mandated experience hours are hands-on by necessity — you cannot supervise your way through clinical hours or an apprenticeship. In architecture, accounting and engineering, the mandated hours are desk-based, and desk work is exactly what is changing.

Architecture is the sharpest case of the three, because a larger share of the traditional AXP was drafting and documentation than in either of the others.

We rate the protection 8.5 because it is currently doing its job. We flag it as the factor most likely to be hollowed out from the inside rather than repealed.

The honest problem, and it isn't AI

Architecture requires the longest path to licensure of any design profession, and the pay does not correspond.

- **Eight to thirteen years** from starting high school to licensure, depending on route
- A five-year B.Arch is the most direct path; an M.Arch adds time for career changers
- The AXP experience requirement, then six ARE exam divisions — most candidates take 18 to 30 months just to pass the exams, at roughly $1,500–$2,000 in fees on top of tuition
- Median architect pay sits around **$99,270** according to BLS, with projected growth of 4–5%

Now the comparison that matters, and it's uncomfortable. Construction managers and engineers reach broadly similar salaries by materially shorter routes — and in our index, construction management scores 3.3 and licensed engineering 4.0 against architecture's 5.0.

Shorter path. Better protection. Comparable money.

That is not an argument against architecture. It's an argument that architecture has to be chosen for the work rather than for the return, because on return alone the adjacent professions win.

One genuine bright spot in the pay data. The AIA's Compensation Report — covering 13,227 positions across 817 firms — finds licensure is the single largest salary multiplier in the profession: unlicensed professionals in their first five years earn roughly $52,000–$78,000, and licensure lifts that to $78,000–$105,000, an 18–35% increase.

The licence is the product. Everything in this profile points at completing it.

What the trend shows

Licensed architecture: 4.3 → 4.6 → 5.0. Up 0.7.

Production drafting: 6.1 → 7.0 → 7.6. Up 1.5 — more than double the pace.

The gap widened from 1.8 points to 2.6. And the drafting displacement is visible in the pay data as well as ours: 2D CAD drafters average $48,000–$58,000 and the role is shrinking, while BIM technicians with three to five years of project experience command $58,000–$78,000 because demand exceeds supply.

Even inside the exposed tier, the split is between operating a tool and understanding a model.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Regulatory / licensing	Strong	**Most durable — with a caveat**	Moves at the speed of legislation. But see section 4 on what logged hours now contain.
Human trust / accountability	Strong	**Durable**	Clients want a named human answerable for a building.
Judgment under novelty	Strong	**Eroding slowly**	Site-specific judgment resists; standard-case design does not.
Physical / embodied	Real for site work	**Durable for construction administration**	Construction sites are among the hardest environments for automation.

The honest read. Architecture's protections are genuine, and they concentrate at the licensed, site-attending end. A student who completes the licence and stays close to buildings is well positioned. One who stops at production work is in the most exposed part of the profession.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Drawing the set	Specifying it, then checking what was generated
Producing three design options	Choosing among fifty generated ones
Rendering by hand	Rendering instantly; judging what to show
Checking code manually	Verifying automated compliance output
Learning the craft by drafting for years	Learning it... some other way, still unresolved
Signing the drawings	**Unchanged**

One consequence worth naming. The value moves upstream — toward specifying the problem and judging the answer, away from producing the artefact. That's good news for architects who want to be responsible for buildings, and less good for anyone who chose architecture because they love drawing.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Site judgment** — reading actual conditions against what the drawings claim. The least

> automatable thing in the profession.

2. **Accountability** — carrying the stamp and the liability. 3. **Design judgment on genuine novelty** — an unusual programme, a difficult site, a

> constraint nobody has solved this way before.

4. **Client and stakeholder handling** — architecture is a coordination profession as much as a

> design one.

5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated design is buildable on screen and not in reality.

Notably absent: drafting speed, rendering skill and software fluency in any particular package. These were the traditional markers of a strong graduate and are the fastest-depreciating.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The work is genuinely distinctive, and it's why people persist through a long path. You make things that exist for decades, that people occupy, and that shape how they feel. Very few careers offer that at all.

- **Median pay around $99,270**, above the median for all occupations
- **Roughly 7,800–12,100 annual openings**, with employment projected to grow 4–5%
- Licensure lifts pay 18–35%, the largest single multiplier in the profession

- **The licensure pipeline has shrunk**, pushing licensed salaries up faster than in most of the previous decade
- **Specialisation pays sharply**: healthcare architecture commands an 18–30% premium, and data centre and laboratory design a 20–35% premium — the AI buildout creating architectural demand in the same way it created electrical demand

Small firms pay slightly below market and offer faster advancement, more varied work and more creative autonomy — a genuine trade-off rather than simply worse.

What's genuinely hard about it

The length, covered in section 5, and it is the dominant issue.

The work is less creative than students expect. Most architects spend significant time on technical documentation rather than design, especially early on. Only senior designers and principals spend the majority of their time on creative work.

Hours during deadlines are long — 50 to 70 hours a week is common in crunch periods.

Pay compression between levels is a recognised cause of senior attrition, according to industry compensation analysis: the gap between a mid-level and a senior architect is often smaller than the difference in responsibility.

And geography matters enormously. West Coast pay runs around 25% above national average and the South around 6% below, so the same qualification produces very different outcomes depending on where someone practises.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Architecture tends to suit people who:

- **Want to make things that persist** — the single most-cited reason people stay
- **Can hold a long horizon.** The rewards arrive late, and the first decade is documentation.
- **Enjoy constraint** — code, budget, physics, client. Architecture is design inside hard limits.
- **Are comfortable coordinating people who disagree** — engineers, contractors, clients, planners
- **Can absorb criticism of work they care about**

It's harder for people who:

- Expect **creative work early**. It arrives around year eight to twelve.
- Need **strong early earnings**
- Dislike **documentation and regulation**, which is most of the early job
- Are drawn to the **image** of architecture rather than the practice

What else is moving this market

Construction cycles drive everything. Architecture is more cyclical than engineering and much more so than healthcare or education.

Sustainability and retrofit are growing, driven by regulation rather than technology, and sustainable design specialists earn a 15–25% premium.

And the data centre and laboratory boom is a genuine tailwind — the highest specialisation premium in the profession, and directly downstream of the same AI buildout that threatens other careers.

The AI-native advantage — what to actually do about it

The situation: generative design, automated compliance checking and instant visualisation are established in large practices. The people who can direct and verify them are not.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE ARCHITECT LOOKS LIKE

1. Verify. Knowing when a generated design is buildable on screen and not in reality. This requires understanding construction well enough to catch a plausible error, which is why site exposure matters more than it used to.

2. Specify. Framing the constraint set precisely enough that generated options are usable. The skill has moved upstream from drawing to briefing.

3. Judge applicability. Knowing whether a standard solution fits this site, this contractor, this jurisdiction.

4. Own the stamp. Everything here points at licensure. Start the AXP deliberately and finish it.

5. Bridge model and site. Being the person who connects what the model says with what the site shows. That is where the two protected tracks meet.

CONCRETE PREPARATION

Before the degree: understand the length honestly, and look at construction management and engineering alongside it — not as lesser options, but because they reach comparable money faster with better scores.

During: seek site exposure specifically, not just studio and office work. Take computational design and building science seriously — those are the specialist tracks that pay. And treat the technical modules as what verification will later depend on.

After: start the AXP immediately and treat the exams as a project rather than something to get around to. Every year of delay costs the 18–35% licensure premium.

The routes in

ROUTE	TYPICAL LENGTH	NOTES
Five-year B.Arch	5 years	The most direct accredited route.
Four-year pre-professional + M.Arch	6–7 years	Common, and flexible for those uncertain at eighteen.
M.Arch for career changers	3–4 years post-degree	Genuine route in from another discipline.
AXP + ARE	+3–5 years typically	The licensure stage. Fees around $1,750–$2,350 in total.
Architectural technologist / BIM route	Varies	Faster to earnings, but lands in the more exposed tier unless it leads to licensure.

Where an architecture degree can take them later

Broader than people assume: practice and design leadership, construction administration, project and construction management, urban design and planning, sustainability and building performance, computational design, real estate development, and heritage and conservation.

The pattern in this index holds: the further from the site and the signature, the higher the exposure. Visualisation and drafting-adjacent roles score worst; construction administration and development score best.

What to look for in an architecture program

1. Accreditation for licensure. Non-negotiable. Check it directly against the jurisdiction where they intend to practise.

2. Integrated practice experience — and whether it includes site time. Office placement is good; site exposure is better and rarer.

3. Technical depth in building science and computational design. These are the specialist tracks with real premiums.

4. Does the studio teach design judgment or software? A curriculum organised around tools is training for the exposed tier.

5. Licensure support and outcomes. What proportion of graduates are licensed at five and ten years? This is the number that matters and it is rarely published.

Questions to ask an architecture program

On licensure:

- Is the programme accredited for licensure where I intend to practise?
- What proportion of your graduates are licensed within five years? Within ten?
- What support exists for AXP hours and ARE preparation?

On practice:

- How much placement or practice experience is built in, and does any of it involve site work?
- How much of the curriculum is building science, construction technology and computational design?

On AI:

- How does the programme teach students to work with generative design and automated compliance tools — and to check them?
- What changed in the curriculum in the last two years?

On outcomes:

- What job titles do graduates hold at six months and at five years?
- What's your attrition rate through the degree?

Red flags: unclear accreditation; no site exposure; no licensure tracking; a curriculum organised around software packages; vagueness about how long graduates actually take to qualify.

Go deeper — further reading

- **Architects — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — *US Bureau of Labor Statistics*. Primary source and free: median pay, projected growth, annual openings and licensure requirements. Read the **Construction Managers** and **Civil Engineers** entries alongside it — the comparison is the most useful thing you can do before committing to this path.
- **NCARB — becoming an architect** — the National Council of Architectural Registration Boards is the authority on licensure. The AXP and ARE requirements, timelines and fees come from here rather than from any university prospectus.
- **How long does it take to become an architect?** — a clear breakdown of the eight-to-thirteen-year path, the exam structure and the real costs. Worth reading with your child rather than about them.

The counterargument — read this one:

> The strongest case against our 5.0 is that we are **crediting the stamp with protection that the market is quietly removing**.
>
> Architecture is unusual in that its most exposed tier — drafting and documentation — is also the tier most easily offshored. Firms have been sending BIM and drafting work overseas for years, and generative tools accelerate rather than initiate that. On this reading, the erosion of the entry tier is a labour-cost story with an AI accelerant, and our framework over-attributes it to the technology.
>
> There's a version that cuts the other way too: if the licensure pipeline keeps shrinking while construction demand holds, licensed architects become scarcer and better paid — which the 2024–25 salary data already shows. On that reading our 5.0 may be too *high* for the licensed tier.

> **Where we land:** we think both are partly right, and they affect different tiers. Offshoring and automation compound at the drafting end, which is why it scores 7.6. Scarcity protects the licensed end, which is why it scores 5.0 rather than 6. What we're watching is the licensure rate — if the proportion of graduates who qualify keeps falling, the profession has a pipeline problem that will eventually show up as either higher pay or lower standards, and we'll report which.

Bottom line

Architecture is well protected at the licensed end and the honest problems have nothing to do with AI.

The stamp is a legal monopoly, site work cannot be done remotely, and clients want a named human answerable for a building. Those hold.

But this is the longest path to licensure of any design profession — eight to thirteen years — and the pay does not correspond to that length. Construction managers and engineers reach similar money by shorter routes, and in this index they score better: 3.3 and 4.0 against architecture's 5.0.

And the logged-hours question is sharper here than anywhere. The AXP mandates supervised experience, which protects the on-ramp — but a larger share of those hours was traditionally drafting than in accounting or engineering, and drafting is exactly what is automating.

So the useful advice is: commit to licensure or don't start, because the licence is worth 18–35% and everything in the profession points at it. Get site exposure rather than only studio and office. Specialise deliberately — healthcare, laboratory and data centre work carry the largest premiums, and sustainability is growing. And look seriously at construction management and engineering first, not as consolation prizes but because they reach comparable outcomes faster.

And one thing worth saying to a seventeen-year-old who genuinely wants this. You make things that stand for decades and that people live inside. Very few careers offer that, and no score measures it. Choose it for that, with the length in front of you — not for the return, because on return alone the adjacent professions win.

Discussion questions

Part 1 — About the work itself

1. What made architecture appealing? Push past "I like design" to something specific — a

> building, a moment, a problem.

2. **Do they want to design, or to build?** Those point to different careers, and construction

> management is the under-considered one.

3. Do they know that most of the first decade is technical documentation rather than design? 4. Can they work inside hard constraints — code, budget, physics, client — or does that feel

> limiting?

Part 2 — Reacting to the findings

5. Licensed architecture scores 5.0; construction management 3.3 and licensed engineering 4.0.

> Does that change anything?

6. Production drafting scores 7.6. Does that affect how they think about the early years? 7. The profile raises a question about whether logged AXP hours still build the same judgment.

> What do they make of that?

Part 2b — The harder conversation

8. **Eight to thirteen years to licensure.** Have they pictured that concretely — where they'd

> be at 25, at 30?

9. Have you looked at what architects actually earn against construction managers and engineers,

> who get there faster?

10. Hours of 50–70 a week during deadlines. Is that understood?

Part 2c — The other side

11. Of what architects find rewarding — making things that persist, shaping how people

> experience space, solving constrained problems — which matters most?

12. Looking at "who this work suits": which items sound like them? Answer separately, then

> compare.

13. Can they wait until year eight or ten for the creative work to arrive?

Part 2d — The AI question, practically

14. Generative tools now produce fifty design options in the time it took to draw one. Does that

> sound exciting or threatening to them?

15. The value is moving from producing drawings to specifying and judging. Does that fit what

> they want to do?

Part 3 — Testing it against reality

16. **The most valuable single action:** visit a construction site, not just a building. The gap

> between the drawing and the reality is the profession.

17. Find an architect five to ten years in and ask what they actually do all day, and how long

> licensure took them.

Part 4 — About the program

18. Is the programme accredited for licensure where they intend to practise? Check directly. 19. Ask the licensure-rate question from section 13 — what proportion qualify within five years? 20. How much site exposure is built in?

Part 5 — Widening the frame

21. **Have they seriously considered construction management?** Better score, shorter path,

> chronically short of people, and trade-to-supervision is a normal route.

22. What about civil or structural engineering? Similar money, shorter path, stronger licence. 23. If architecture weren't available, what would they choose? The answer usually reveals what

> they're actually drawn to.

Part 6 — For the parent, alone

24. Am I attracted to the prestige of this on their behalf? 25. Am I prepared to support eight to thirteen years, including the exam period? 26. Have I actually compared the pay against the adjacent careers, or assumed? 27. What's the one thing I most want them to understand — in a sentence, without a number in it?

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For architecture specifically, we've flagged that the profession's most significant problems — the length of the path and pay relative to that length — sit entirely outside what our six factors measure.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Architecture

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

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1. The formula

```
Risk = 0.35 × Automatability
     + 0.15 × EntryErosion
     + 0.15 × (10 − Physical)
     + 0.15 × (10 − Trust)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Regulatory)
     + 0.10 × (10 − Judgment)
```

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

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2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-seven careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No licence exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent*, *where being wrong is costly*?

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

CONSTRUCTION ADMINISTRATION / SITE — 4.7 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	7.4	8.1	**9.1**	3.18
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.0	3.4	**3.8**	0.57
Physical / embodied	15%	7.5	7.5	**7.5**	0.38
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.22
Regulatory / licensing	10%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.15
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
				Total	**4.7 → 4.7**

LICENSED ARCHITECT / DESIGN LEAD — 5.0 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	7.8	8.5	**9.4**	3.29
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.2	3.6	**4.0**	0.6
Physical / embodied	15%	6.5	6.5	**6.5**	0.53
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.22
Regulatory / licensing	10%	8.5	8.5	**8.5**	0.15
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
				Total	**4.99 → 5.0**

SPECIALIST (SUSTAINABILITY, COMPUTATIONAL) — 5.5 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	8.1	9.1	**9.8**	3.43
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	3.8	**4.2**	0.63
Physical / embodied	15%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.75
Human trust / accountability	15%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.3
Regulatory / licensing	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
Judgment under novelty	10%	8.0	8.0	**8.0**	0.2
				Total	**5.51 → 5.5**

TECHNICAL / BIM COORDINATION — 6.7 (MODERATE–HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.8	8.0	**8.9**	3.11
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.5	5.0	**5.5**	0.82
Physical / embodied	15%	2.5	2.5	**2.5**	1.12
Human trust / accountability	15%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.67
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.5	5.5	**5.5**	0.45
Judgment under novelty	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
				Total	**6.69 → 6.7**

PRODUCTION DRAFTING — 7.6 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.1	8.3	**9.7**	3.39
Entry-path erosion	15%	5.5	6.5	**7.2**	1.08
Physical / embodied	15%	2.0	2.0	**2.0**	1.2
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.5	4.5	**4.5**	0.82
Regulatory / licensing	10%	5.0	5.0	**5.0**	0.5
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.0	4.0	**4.0**	0.6
				Total	**7.6 → 7.6**

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Construction administration / site

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	7.4	3.0	0.95	**4.0**
2025	8.1	3.4	0.95	**4.3**
Fall 2026	9.1	3.8	0.95	**4.7**

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.59** and entry-path erosion **+0.12**, for a total of **+0.7** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labour market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

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7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.